

# Saga of John of Holar

Bishops' Sagas

Norse Sagas

*translated by Frederick York, 1905*

Plato Scroll · **plato-scroll.com**



*Scan to read online, free and offline*

*[plato-scroll.com/s/norse-saga-of-john-of-holar/](https://plato-scroll.com/s/norse-saga-of-john-of-holar/)*

## THE LIFE OF S. JOHN THE BISHOP

1

1. 1. WE begin the story or record of the holy bishop John in the days when Harold Sigurd's son was ruling Norway, and there were passed from the fall of king Olaf the Saint two-and-twenty winters. In that time was the holy bishop John born in a homestead in Fleet's- lithe that is called Broad-bowster. His father was named Og-mund. The father of Og-mund was named Thor-kel, and was the son of As-gar Cneif. The mother of bishop John was named Thor-gerd. She was the daughter of Egil the son of Hall o' Side, who was the man who had the fortune to be the first of the chiefs of the East-frith-men's Quarter to take baptism and the true faith. Thor-gerd's mother was named Thor-laug. [She was] the daughter of Thor-wald o' Ridge.

2

2. The holy bishop John grew up at home with his father and mother at Broad-bowster until he was five winters old, and then there came about great tidings and ones which all the people of this land were greatly rejoiced at — to wit, the consecration as bishop of Is-laf, the son of Gizor the White, and daughter's son of Thor-odd gode, according to the prayer of the whole people of this country. He was hallowed bishop by Adalbert, archbishop of Bremen in Saxland [Saxony], in the days of Leo, the ninth pope of that name. Is-laf was taught in Saxland in the town that is called Herfurd [Herford], He was the first consecrated to be bishop of this country that has had his see here. Many bishops had come into this country aforetime which had not been consecrated to be bishops of this country; some were here very many winters, and some a short while. Is-laf was in Norway the next winter after he was consecrated bishop, and afterwards he went to Iceland, and came out hither the next summer after the great famine [1057], and set up his see and his home in his own paternal heritage at Seal-holt. [Gp. *Hungrv* ch. 1. 3, 4.]

3

3. It was early the prediction of wise folk what a man he would come to be, this holy bishop John, for wherever he went men were impressed when they looked in his countenance.

4

4. There was a man named Godwine, and he was called Godwine the Good, and men believe that he was so indeed. He saw the holy bishop John when he was yet a child, and spake of him in these words, 'That is a fair child, and he hath in him a great appearance of holiness.' And now it hath come to pass according to the saw, 'What wise men say' will come to pass.'

5

2. 1. WHEN John was yet a child his father and mother broke up housekeeping and went abroad together. They came to Denmark and went to king Swein, and the king received them worshipfully, and Thor-gerd was made to sit by the queen herself, Est-rith, the mother of king Swein. Thor-gerd had her son the holy [bishop] John at the table with her, and when many kinds of precious dainties with good drink came to the king's table, then it happened with the boy John, as is ever the way with children, that he stretched out his hands to the things he wished to have. But his mother would have chidden him, and smote his hands. But when queen Est-rith saw this, she spake to Thor-gerd, 'Not so, not so, Thor-gerd mine; do not strike those hands, for they are bishop's hands.' Now from such an occurrence it may be seen, as we have said before, what wise folk thought of him, and they foresaw what afterwards came to pass, by God's providence, with respect to the holy bishop John.

6

2. It is also needful to put down what the holy king Olaf said to Thor-gerd, mother of the holy bishop John. She was then eight winters old when she went to Norway with her father and mother. Egil went into the service of the holy king Olaf, and was well treated there, as were all other worshipful men of Iceland that came thither. But when it drew

on to Yule, Egil began to be sad. The king espied it, and asked him what was the matter. Egil said it was naught; but when the king enquired into it, then Egil told him that if there were anything amiss it was rather this, that Thor-laug his wife would not be treated as honourably as himself when they held the glorious feast that was then close at hand. The king said that he would put this to rights, and asked her to spend Yule with him, and her daughter also. And on Yule evening, when they were walking up the hall with queen Est-rith, and they were given seats for them close to the queen, the king espied the maid, and afterwards said to Egil her father, 'This daughter of thine seems to me a fair maid and of goodly bearing, and I can tell thee that she will be a lucky lady, and it shall be the noblest family in Iceland that shall spring from her.' And now that hath fairly come to pass as was to be looked for indeed, which the holy man spake, and hath been shown forth in this holy man bishop John her son, for he indeed is truly noble, that was honoured by the choice of many men and glorified with the office of bishop while he lived in this world, and now he shineth by fair miracles, and hath become of great help to all them that seek his intercession with Almighty God.

7

3. 1. WHEN the father and mother of John had been abroad such while as they thought good, they went back to Iceland again, and settled down in their homestead at Broad-bovvster. And when the holy [bishop] John was grown to be a big boy, his father put him to school to bishop Is-laf. And he grew up in his charge, and soon grew ripe in holy learning and good manners, for in bishop Is-laf he had the best means of getting both.

8

2-3. [See Hungrv. 1. 7 b, and 2.] Hall of Hawk-dale fostered Tait. Tait, bishop Is-laf's son, fostered and taught many clerks. Two of his disciples afterwards became bishops, viz bishop Thor-lac the first, and bishop Beorn of Holar.

9

4. Bishop Is-laf soon saw how well his fosterling John was getting on with his learning and the other good things which he taught him with fair ensamples and goodly conversation. Then he began to cherish him greatly, and hold him of much account in many ways, and others soon did the same after his example.

10

5. The holy [bishop] John was a big man of growth, the most goodly and handsome of men, the best-eyed of any man, light of hair, and strong of body, and the best-favoured in his whole carriage; but no matter how well-favoured he was in all men's sight in his bearing, yet he was not a whit less remarked for the gentleness and lowliness of his speech to all people. And so by God's help he brought it about that he became dear both to God and to good men.

11

6. Now it hath become needful to say somewhat of this also, in what account the holy bishop John held his foster-father bishop Is-laf, for as men of wisdom and knowledge say, it was ever in bishop John's mouth when he happened to be by when men were talking among themselves of the man whom they held the best. 'Bishop Is-laf, my foster-father,' he would say, 'was the handsomest of all men, the cleverest of all men, the best of all men.' Then they that had been talking before would answer the bishop, 'Who was speaking, my lord, of bishop Is-laf?' And the holy bishop John would answer, 'I must needs speak of him whenever I hear a good man spoken of.' Now this was a fair testimony to bishop Is-laf that a holy man should speak so of him, and a great honour to bishop John that such a man should have fostered him.

12

7. This thing is also specially spoken of which the holy bishop John had had above all other men — to wit, that he was better voiced than any man, and hereof shall be some token spoken of later in this history, that wise men have held that it was so.

13

4. 1. THE holy bishop John was minded to go abroad, and he was then a deacon in orders, and well-nigh a full-grown man, and he yearned to see the ways of good men, and to increase his learning both for his own profit and for that of many others, as was afterwards proven. So he went first to Norway, and thence to Denmark, and never stayed on his way tjll he went south and sought the holy apostle Peter in his own place, and afterwards he turned back thence and came to Denmark on the day of the Lord's Passion. And king Swein was still alive, and he sought to him to see him.

14

2. And when he was come to the place where the king was, it was then told him that the king was at mass. But the priest that was to sing the mass began to read the Passion as the holy John came into the church. But he read the lesson so slowly and with such difficulty that they that stood by thought it heavy and wearisome to hear. But when the holy John found that the priest was well-nigh become a laughingstock to men, then he laid a stole over his shoulders, and walked up to the priest and took the book out of his hand in lowly fashion, and read the Passion so nobly and clearly that all they that stood by marvelled. And when the service was over the king sent after him, and asked him to him, and bade him stay a long while with him, and paid him so great honour that he put him next himself, and was pleased that he should stay with him as long as he would, and indeed he stayed with him a good while.

15

3. During the time while the holy John was with king Swein he was honoured by God with noble forebodings, and one day when he came to the king's table, he himself told the king what he had seen in a dream. 'Methought in the night that I was standing in a certain cathedral of marvellous splendour, and in the choir of the church, as it were in the bishop's seat, I saw our Lord Jesus Christ sitting, and on a foot-stool at His feet I saw the holy king David sitting, and smiting his harp with most noble skill and most fair music; and indeed I think, my

lord, that there hath remained in my mind somewhat of that fair music that he made. Now do thou, my lord, let them bring me a harp, and I will try before thee if I can remember somewhat of the music he made.' Then the king bade them bring a harp and give it to John, and he took the harp and tuned it, and smote it with so great skill that the king himself and all they that stood by cried out how well he played. All to whom this was told thought this thing to be of great import, and all they praised Almighty God that deigneth to manifest the glory of His saints.

16

4. Nor can this be left out how great succour the Icelanders got both abroad and at home from the holy bishop John. We will tell this first, how he found out and brought back from abroad hither along with him Sæ-mund Sigfusson, the man that of all others hath been of the greatest profit to God's Church in this country, when he had been away so long that there were no news at all of him. But the holy John got news of him, and brought him back with him from the south, and they both journeyed together from the south out hither to their kinsfolk and their foster-land.

17

5. When the holy John was abroad this time king Magnus, the son of Olaf [the Quiet], the son of Harold Sigurdsson, was ruling over Norway, and when John came north into Thrond-ham the king was there. At that time there were in Norway many Icelanders, and Tait the son of bishop Gizor was there then. And it came to pass that a man of Iceland, whose name was Gisl [Illuge's son the poet], slew a man, and the man that was slain was a house-carl of king Magnus. But Gisl was driven to this rash deed because he had to avenge his father, and the man whom Gisl slew was named Giaf-wald [Gieb-wald]; he had been at the slaying of Illuge, Gisl's father. And soon after the slaying Gisl was taken and fettered by the king's men. But when the Icelanders heard of it, straightway they all went together to the house wherein Gisl was, Tait being the leader of their company, and hewed off his fetters and took

him away with them. But at the news thereof the king let call a Moot, and he was exceeding wrath, and it looked as if the matter would turn out very badly [for the Icelanders]. At this Moot no Icelanders were allowed to plead save holy John. The king gave him leave 'to speak, and he pleaded in a long and very fine speech, and it was of such influence that the king's wrath was abated, so that they got quarter and peace that before were well-nigh doomed to death [1096-7].

18

5. 1. AFTER this there came out hither to Iceland John and Sæ-mund, and settled down each on his father's heritage, John at Broad-bowster, and Sæ-mund at Ord, and there they both dwelt a very long while, and there was brotherly love and holy communion between them, and they were like unto one another in many good things. They were also near of a like age, as far as we can guess, but John was two winters the elder. They both adorned the holy churches which they had to keep in many ways, serving them humbly in their priesthood and increasing their rights greatly with respect to provision of clerks, so that they should have each church served more often than it had been before. They might also rightly be called Pillars of the Church, for they upheld her fairly in their holy teaching, and many other goodly endowments which went forth from them upon all them that were near them, or that would hearken to or accept their wholesome admonitions.

19

2. Now the holy John was married and had two wives, and the first one lived but a short while, and by neither had he any children that grew up out of childhood, or that we have heard tell of.

20

3. When Almighty God was minded to raise up His servant the holy John to an higher degree of clerkly honour than he was in before, the North-landers prayed bishop Gizor that he would set up a bishop's see in the North-landers Quarter, because they said they were so far off, and their Quarter was the most thickly inhabited and the greatest, wherefore they needed most the visitations of the bishop, but could

most seldom get them. Bishop Gizor laid this matter before the men of most understanding, and they all agreed together that it would be a good thing to grant them their prayer, and chiefly because they thought it would be a great support to the Church of God, and that it would be less likely that the land should be long bishopless if there were two bishops. Whereupon it was now settled in such wise that bishop Gizor gave up more than a fourth part of his bishopric, to the end that there should be a bishop's see in the North-landers Quarter, as the North-landers had prayed. And to this office and honour and bishopric over the North-landers Quarter and the North-landers, bishop Gizor chose priest John Og-mund's son, with the consent of all clerks and laymen in the North-landers Quarter. And although the holy John at first made many excuses for not taking the office by reason of his humility, yet at the last he gave way at the prayer of bishop Gizor, and consented to go abroad and take bishop's orders if God would have it so.

21

7. 1. Now after this there were many meetings held, and it was settled at the end that the see of the bishop of the North-landers should be set north in Sheltie-dale, at the homestead that is called Holar [the knolls]. There had dwelt a worthy priest who was called Illoge [*Latinised Hilarius*], and was the son of Beorn. He was the only one of the men of worship of the North-landers Quarter to rise up from the heritage of his fathers for God's sake and the needs of Holy Church, because there had before been long shufflings between the chiefs as to which of them should forsake his father's heritage and his home, and there was none of them ready so to do save this man only. And it is easy for all men to see that he did this for God's sake, and he might well hope for that which must have come to pass, that God would give him a fair mansion in everlasting bliss, which may of right be called the heritage of good men. [Now this same Hilarius afterwards went to Broad-bowster in West-hope, and there his body resteth, but his soul is with God in everlasting joy.]

22

2. And this summer the bishop-elect took ship with the following that was appointed for him and moneys, and he took with him a letter and seal of bishop Gizor which bore witness to his errand. And when they were ready they put to sea, and there is nought told of their journey till they got to Denmark, and they had a good voyage. But John the holy bishop-elect forthwith sought the archbishop Auzor, and came to the place where the archbishop was, and [it was] rather late in the day.

23

3. The archbishop was at church at evensong, and when John the holy bishop-elect got to church evensong was well-nigh over. He took his place outside the choir, and began to sing evensong with his clerks. The archbishop had forbidden all his clerks, old and young alike, to look out of the choir while the hours were being sung, and he set a penalty to be taken if this his command were broken. But as soon as the archbishop heard the chanting of the holy John, he looked out down the church trying to see who the man was that had such a voice. But when evensong was over, the archbishop's clerks said to him, 'How now, my lord bishop, have ye not yourself broken the rules ye made?' The archbishop answered, 'I confess that it is true as ye say, but yet I have not done it for nought, for a voice was borne into my ears such as I have never heard before, and it may rather be likened to the voice of an angel than of a man.' Whereby it may be noted, as we have said before in this story, how far the voice of the holy John was before that of most men, according to the judgment of the wise. But when John had finished his evensong, then he went to see the archbishop, and he received him worshipfully, and asked him and his following to stay with him. And when the holy John had been a short while with the archbishop, he set forth his errand to the archbishop, and showed him the letter and seal of bishop Gizor; and when they had considered the matter for certain days with other clerks with whom the bishop wished to consider the matter, and when the matter was thoroughly overhauled, then the archbishop spoke to the bishop-elect: 'I perceive

very well, my very dear brother, that thou hast almost all the qualities that fit thee for a bishop; moreover I believe that that people will be happy which may have such a bishop over them. But by reason of one thing which thou hast told me, that thou hast had two wives, I dare not consecrate thee without the leave of the pope and his own cognizance thereof. Wherefore this is our counsel herein, that thou go as quickly as may be to see the pope, and we will write thee a letter under our seal and acquaint the pope with thy case. And if it go so as we would hope, that he give thee leave to take consecration [as bishop], and us leave to bestow it, then do thou come back to me as quickly as may be, and I will then joyfully accomplish thine errand for thee.'

24

5. After that John the holy bishop-elect went to the city of Rome, and when he was come there his suit was well received by the pope. When John came south the holy Paschalis [Pascal], second of that name, was pope. The holy John declared all his errand to the pope, and showed him withal the archbishop's letter and seal which acquainted the pope with all the conditions of his case, and when the pope had seen the writing he graciously granted the humble prayer that was made to him, and directed the holy bishop-elect to go and see archbishop Auzor, and wrote to him under his seal, and gave him leave to consecrate the holy John bishop.

25

6. And when John had taken the pope's blessing, he went on his way back and came with his following to see archbishop Auzor. And when he was aware by the pope's letter, which the holy John brought from his meeting with the pope, that he was given full freedom to consecrate him, then the archbishop was wonderfully glad, and thanked Almighty God that it should have been granted him to fulfil the errand of the holy John, according to the wish of the people. And now he abode with the archbishop till the time when he should think fit to consecrate him. After this the archbishop calleth together the clerks that were bound to be present at that service, and when all was

prepared then he consecrateth the holy John bishop on the Lord's-day two nights before the mass of the two apostles Philip and James, that is the third of the kalends of May [April 29, 1106]. After the holy John was consecrated he dwelt with the archbishop, and received of him many helpsome counsels profitable both to himself and to the people over whom he was set.

26

7. The holy John was consecrated bishop, as hath been told, when he was four-and-fifty years old. That was in the days of pope Pascal, and in the days of Ey-stan and Sig-urd, kings of Norway. And at that day bishop Gizor had governed God's Church in Iceland as long as bishop Is-laf his father, and that was four-and-twenty winters.

27

8. 1. BISHOP JOHN went out to Iceland the next summer after he was consecrated, and had a good voyage, and soon after they had made land the news of his arrival was known, and all good men were joyful thereat, and forthwith there came together crowds to meet him. He received every man's suit with gentleness, and showed in every way that he had not forgotten the holy humility which was in him before he was consecrated bishop, but rather that he had increased therein with all other good qualities, now that more was required of him since he had been so greatly raised by Almighty God to much honour.

28

2. And as soon as the holy John was ready to leave the ship he went home to his see at Holar, and straightway began to govern well and fairly Almighty God's Church which he was set over, and that winter he stayed at home at his seat. But in the summer he rode to the All-moot, and there he and bishop Gizor met with much joy, and then bishop Gizor apprized the people how much good men had to thank God for in the joyful tidings that had now come about that there were two bishops in the country, which thing had never been before since Christendom came into the land. The bishops talked over many things together that were profitable, and put together with other clerks

[help] the rules which they should set over them that were under their care.

29

3. That summer bishop John began his visitation of his diocese, and set himself to govern God's Christendom with mighty governing; he chastised evil men with the power that was given him on God's behalf, and strengthened good men and them of right conversation in many good ways.

30

9. 1. Now the holy bishop John had sat but a short time at his bishopstead at Holar, before he had the church that was there taken down. This church had been made next after that which Oxe Sholto's son had had built [c. 1030]. Men think that this church which Oxe had made was the biggest church under wooden shingles in all Iceland; and he [Oxe] laid out much means on this church, and had it well fitted within and beautifully, and covered it all with lead. But this church was all burnt with all its vestments by the secret judgment of God. But the holy bishop John had a great and worshipful church built at Holar, which standeth there to-day, although it has been both covered and many other repairs made since [his day]. And the holy bishop John spared nought in the building of this church, that God's glory might be more than before there, and this house [of his] might be fairly built and adorned.

31

2. He chose the man for the church building that was then thought to be the most skilful. His name was Thor-odd, and he was the son of Garnie, and it was so that both the holy John spared not to pay him great and good wages, and he did his work well and honestly. It is told of this man that he was so quick at learning that, when he was at his work, he listened to the priestlings being taught the accomplishment which is called *grammatical* and it stuck so well in his ears, by reason of his great quickness in learning and attention or application, that he became the most accomplished man in this kind of learning.

32

10. 1. WHEN John had been a short while bishop, he had a school set up at home there at the bishopstead, west of the church door, and had it well and beautifully built [and the mark of the houses \*is still to be seen]. And to this end, to govern the school and teach them that should be set there, he chose him a man out of Gotland that was the best and quickest clerk: he was called Gisle, and was the son of Finne. He paid him a great wage, both to teach the priestlings and to give such support to holy Christendom along with the bishop himself as he could manage in his teachings and addresses. And ever when he was preaching before the people, he had a book lying before him, and took therefrom what he spoke to the people, and he did this most out of prudence and humility, because as he was young in years those that listened might lay more store by it, when they saw that he took what he taught out of holy books and not out of his own natural knowledge or breast-wit. And yet so much advantage followed his teachings that the men that listened thereto were much moved, and made great and good changes [in their lives] by his advice. And that which he taught in his words he showed forth also in his works. His teachings were lenient and light to bear to all good, and the wise thought them seemly and interesting, and to the evil they became a great terror and a true chastisement. -

33

2. On all the high feasts there was a great multitude there, for it was then the great business for many men, first to hear the hours, so fairly were they performed there, and also [to hear] the ordinances of the bishop and his precious teachings which were so choice to hear, whether they were spoken by the bishop himself or by this man that hath just now been spoken of.

34

11. 1. BUT a short while had the holy John been bishop before he began to turn men's ways and habits much into another level than that they had been in before. He became full of chastisement to men of

ill- life, but he was blithe and gentle to all good men, and showed in himself that all which he taught in his words he fulfilled in his work. It appeared to wise men that knew his ways that he was seldom unmindful of that which the Lord spake to His disciples, *Luceat lux vestra...* [Math v. 16]. These words go thus: 'Let your light shine before men, so that they may see your good works, and glorify your Father which is in heaven.'

35

2. And the holy bishop John strongly enjoined that which hath been kept since, that men should come to hours on holidays and other set days, and he bade the priests to repeat oftentimes those things which they needed to know. He bade men keep a daily custom, as beseems Christian men, that is to go every day, late or early, to a cross or church, and there mindfully to put up one's prayers. He bade them to have each in his lodging the mark of the holy cross as a safeguard to himself, and as soon as a man woke he was to sign himself and sing first *Credo in Deum* [the creed], and thus speak his belief in Almighty God, and walk all day after armed with the mark of the holy cross, with which he marked himself as soon as he woke, and never to take sleep or meat or drink without signing himself beforehand. He bade every man to learn *Pater Nosier* and *Credo in Deum*, and Mary's Verse [*Ave Maria*], and remember his hours seven times a day, according as David the prophet saith, *Septies in die laudem tibi dixi, Domine Deus meus* [Ps cxix. 164], that is to be interpreted in Northern [speech]—'Seven times a day I have spoken praise to thee, O Lord my God,' and dutifully sing every evening ere he slept *Credo in Deum* and *Pater Noster*. And that we may end this discourse in few words, he got the ways of the people under him so ordered within a short space by God's help, that holy Christendom hath never stood in such blossom in the North-landers Quarter, neither before nor since as it stood then, when the people were so blessed in having such a bishop's government over them.

36

3. Moreover he forbade altogether all evil customs and heathendom and sacrifices, magic and charms, and stood up against them with all his might, for it was not altogether done away with while Christendom was young.

37

He also forbade all omens, which the men of old [heathens] had been wont to take from the coming of the moon and [observance of] days, and dedicating days to heathen men or gods — as it is when they are called Tew's-day, Woden's-day, or Thor's, and so of all the weekdays; but he bade men to keep the reckoning which the holy fathers have set in the scriptures, and call them the Second Day of the week, and the Third Day, and so on — and all other things beside, which he thought sprung from ill roots.

38

4. There was a play men used much, which was unseemly, wherein a man must recite to a woman, and a woman to a man, verses foul and light and not fit to listen to, and this he had abolished and altogether forbade it to be done. Love-poems and songs he would not hear recited or have recited, but he could not get rid of them altogether.

39

[Double text, B.] This play was dear to men before the holy John was bishop, wherein a man would recite to a woman in the dance effeminate and satirical poems, and a woman to a man love-verses. This play he had abolished and strongly forbade it.

40

5. It is told that he came to hear that Clong Thor-stan's son (he that was afterwards bishop in Seal-holt), when he was a priestling and young in years, was reading a book that is called *Ovidius, De Arte [Amatoriâ]*. In this book there is much love-poetry, and he forbade him to read this kind of book, saying that it was heavy work enough for every man to keep himself from fleshly lust and unlawful love, even if he did not irritate his mind with any poetry [Latin] or poems [vernacular] of this kind.

41

6. He was also diligent in pursuing men's evil ways, and he went about hourly to do this, that well-nigh no man came to see him but he managed in some way to better his ways by reason of his godly love, and the pains he took to help every man. And when he set men hard penance by reason of great offences, and they underwent them well and humbly, it was not long before his holy breast that the Holy Ghost had chosen for His dwelling was pained by their afflictions, and he would lighten their penance in some way. And those men whom he had interdicted by reason of his godly love and zeal, those same he would restore mercifully when they had forsaken their faults. And he that loved all the people under him as his brothers and sons, did not batten on or profit by any of their faults or distresses, but he rejoiced when it went well with them, and condoled over all that went otherwise. He was so kind-hearted that he could hardly bear to see or know that a man was in trouble, and so generous and open-handed with the poor, that his peer could scarce be found. He was a true father to all poor folk, he comforted the widows and the fatherless, and never came one in such distress to see him but he got comfort of some kind from his means. He was of such loving carriage to all men, that there was well-nigh no man that would oppose him, and that was more for the sake of the godly love that all men bore him than for bodily fear. And inasmuch as he crushed his own desire in manifold wise, and did God's will, if he found that it did not conform thereto by reason of bodily lust, therefore God repaid him at once then in yoking beneath him all the people under him in holy obedience. And the holy John lived his life according to divine ordinance and good men's judgment or example; he was at his prayers night and day and fasted long, and mortified himself in many ways to the end that he might yield more profit to God than before out of those things that had been committed to his hand.

42

12. 1. AND to this end that he might be more freer than before to keep the hours and ordinances, and to perform the other things by which God's Christendom *or* Church was most maintained, he chose him men to look after the [bishop]stead with him, that should overlook that which belonged to the stead along with that noble lady, whose name was Wal-dis, whom he had wedded before.

43

2. One of them was a worshipful priest, whose name was Heah-mund, Beorn's son; he was the grandfather of Hilda, nun and anchoress [as shall be told of later in this discourse]. Next to Heah-mund in the administration was the priest whose name was Healte, and he was a kinsman of the bishop. Of laymen there was one in the administration with them that was of noble family, his name was Orn, and he was the son of Thor-lac of Withe-mere. These men took chief care of what appertained to the stead, and appointed men their occupations, some to gathering to the stead all that was thought needful. Some were set to work, some to serve the poor (and the bishop was strict in this that this should be mercifully done), some to receive the guests, because at any feast *or* high-tide there would come to see the bishop a hundred or whiles two hundred men, and sometimes more, for the holy John more- over had laid it down that he was not satisfied save every man in his hundred *or* diocese, that had the use of his feet, came to him at the least once in the twelve-months to visit the bishopstead at Holar. By reason of which there was such a multitude there on Maundy *or* Sheer-monday and Easter, that there were not less than four hundred [480] persons altogether, men and women. And although many of these men had provisions with them, there were many more that were at the bishop's cost, and were fulfilled of him both with spiritual and bodily food, and strengthened by his bishoply blessing they used to go away with joy to their own home.

44

3. Many men of good conversation moved their homes to the bishopstead, and paid money of their own [for their keep], but some kept

themselves, in order to hear the bishop's teachings and the performance of the hours. And they made their houses round about the churchyard.

45

4. Holy bishop John took many men as disciples, and gave them good masters to teach them: Gisle Finsson, whom we spoke of before, to teach *grammatica*; and Rikine the priest a Frenchman, his chaplain and dear friend, to teach singing and verse-making, because he was a most learned man. There was well-nigh no house then, but there was some occupation going on within it that was profitable. It was the elder men's custom to teach the younger, and the younger were writing between their lessons. They were all of one mind and did not fall out, and never envied each other, and as soon as the hours were sung they all came and performed their hours with great attention. There was nothing to be heard in the choir but fair song and holy prayer, for the elder men knew well how to behave, and the children were so chastised by their masters that they dared not behave naughtily.

46

5. These *are the* clerks *that* were bred up under the hands of bishop John: Clong, that was before-named, who was afterwards bishop in Seal-holt, and adorned the bishopstead by his making of books. And he was there through the days of bishop Cetil, and also of bishop Beorn, in friendship with all good men. There was taught also Wil- mund, the first abbot at Thing-ore, and abbot Hran [third of Thin- gore]. There was taught also bishop Beorn, who was the third bishop of Holar. Many other worshipful clerks were bred up and taught there, although we do not name them.

47

13. 1. WHEN the holy bishop John had been a short while set in his bishop-stool, the estate of men became very hard. There pressed upon them a great famine, and much [polar] ice and cold seasons, so that the earth was not green at the spring-moot [c. May 15]. And the holy bishop John went to the spring-moot that was at Thing-ore, and when

he came there then he made a vow for good seasons, with the consent of all men, that they would raise a church and homestead and all contribute till the stead was established. After this vow the holy John put off his cloak and himself marked out the foundation wall for the church. And men's estate turned to the better straightway, so that that same week all the ice was gone from which the famine had in great part come, so that none could be seen, and the earth began to grow green at once, and that same week there was sheep-pasture well-nigh sufficient.

48

2. This thing happened at the homestead at Holar, that there was a stall in the byre in which it would not do to tie up kine, for every one lay dead in the morning that had been tied up the evening before. It happened one harvest-tide that the holy bishop John went with his steward to settle which cattle were to be kept [through the winter] of them that should be stalled at the homestead; and when they had fixed this, the herdsman told him particularly that the kine would not have room enough, inasmuch as one stall was unclean [haunted]. The bishop said it should be so as he said and had fixed, and told him that he was to tie kine in that stall as [he did] in the others, and so it was done. But the morning after, when they came to the byre, there lay a cow in that very stall and she was dead. The bishop was told of this, and he bade them tie up another beast there, and then a third, and they died. Then the herdsman said to the bishop, 'How long is it to go on in this way?' The bishop answers, 'It shall go on as long as there are any kine left, if God will that the place be wasted in this way.' After that it stopped, and so bishop John won a victory over this evil oppression by his faith and steadfastness.

49

3. It happened on a certain spring that the spring was so late that the earth was but of little verdure at the flitting-days [end of May], Then the holy bishop John rode to the All-moot and made a vow for the bettering of the seasons for men on John the Baptist's day [June 24].

And when he had made his vow and plighted it, he followed it with these words, 'I would that God would give us dew now at once,' and thereby it was manifest that he was a man that could not bear to wait. The summer had been droughty up to then, so that there had not fallen any dew, wherefore there was next to no grass. And when the holy bishop John made his vow the weather was then fine and clear, and not a speck to be seen in the heavens. But when he began the *Gloria in excelsis* that day at mass there came so great a rain from heaven that men thought it unbearable to be out of doors by reason of the wet weather. Thenceforward through the summer there were dews by night and sunshine by day, and so it went on for some time, and the grass crop was a middling one that summer.

50

4. This holy bishop John then was granted by God many markworthy portents or omens and fair visions, and it was not very wonderful that there were many markworthy things shown to him in dreams, for he took no more sleep than the least he could do with, and his mind was ever [set] before he slept and immediately he awoke on God's service and holy offices of prayer.

51

5. He had a vision the same night that there died south in Seal-holt priest Thor-kel, his foster-brother, who was called by a second name Trandill. He was the most worthy clerk. It happened after evensong, when the holy bishop was come to bed, and as soon as ever he laid his head on to the pillow there fell a drowsiness upon him, and he thought that a man came in whom he did not know, and took his stand in the middle of the hall. He thought that this man was asked by them that were there if he could tell any tidings, and he said, 'Thor-kel sainted.' He spake no more. The bishop woke and sprang up at once and called to Rikinne his arch-priest, and spake to him, 'Rise up, brother, and let us go to church and praise Almighty God, for priest Thor-kel our brother is now departed out of this life, and let us commend his soul to the hands of Almighty God.' They had heard that he was sick. Then they

went to church and did the office for the dead, and then he told the priest Rikinne the vision he had had.

52

*[Quotation from Libellas follows in MS.]*

53

6. Once on a time, when holy bishop John had laid him down one night to sleep, he had this vision. He thought that he was at his prayers before a great rood-cross, and straightway he thought that the image on the cross bent itself down to him, and spake certain words in his ear, and we know not what they were. This vision he told to Rikinne the priest, and there was no one that could interpret it. But the next day after there came to see the holy bishop John certain men, newly come from the sea, bringing him a book. In this book was this event written which was then little known in this land. It was said that the Jews had tortured the image of our Lord Jesus Christ on a cross in that city which is called Beyrout, after the manner in which they had aforetime tortured our Lord Jesus Christ [himself]. They beat the image with lashes and spat upon it, and slapped it on the neck. After that they fastened it to the cross, and then went before the cross mocking the image, after the ensample of the Jews aforetime. After that they took a spear and thrust it cruelly into the side of the image. Then came to pass a marvellous thing and never heard of before. Water mingled with blood ran out of the side of the image, and by this water and blood many sick folk gat health. And when the Jews beheld this thing all together they repented with all their heart and turned to God. And when holy bishop John and priest Rikinne had read this thing, the priest spake to the bishop smiling, 'See here now, father, the dream that the Lord showed thee in the night!' 'It is true,' says the bishop, 'and let us praise God!' And then they both praised the Lord Jesus Christ.

54

\* \* \* \* \*

55

14. 1. BUT when the time was come when Almighty God was minded to give an everlasting reward to the holy bishop John for the toil and trouble with great tribulations which he had borne for God's sake, then the holy bishop John fell ill, and of this same illness he departed this life. The illness was not violent, but he was able to set in order and consider all things as he wished them to be. And when he lay in this illness and was not yet anointed, there came to him one of his disciples, a good scribe and a man beloved, a priest in orders. His name was Thorward, and he was called Knop of Knop-dale. He had with him a book which he had written and made for a priest that was at that time far away, and he had prayed him much to make the book, and they had agreed between them that the bishop should set a price on the book and the priest should buy it at that price. The bishop welcomed the priest and spake blithely to him: 'Come to me, my son, and give thy father the kiss of peace ere that I die like other brothers of thine.' Then the priest went up to him and kissed him. After that he showed him the book, and told him what they had agreed between them as to his fixing the price, and prayed him to put a price on the book. The bishop looked at the book and praised it much, and then said, 'Good is this book, and well is it written, but it is not granted to him to have the book. Some other man will get it.' The priest answers, 'Why, father? Do thou put a price on it, and he will gladly pay that for it, for he prayed me much to make him such a book.' The bishop answers, 'I will do this if thou wilt, and put a price on the book, but there is no need so to do, for this same priest that thou didst mean the book for is now dead.' It was some while between this and the time when the news came of the death of this same priest. And he was dead at the time when the bishop spake of his death. All men thought it a great thing that the holy bishop John should know such a thing when he was far away from where it happened.

56

2. And now the holy bishop John began to sink fast, and though his strength was ebbing out, yet he kept ever his offices of prayer as long

as he could speak. After that he had himself anointed, and there were present all the clerks that were at the bishop's see, and other of his friends. He had already before ordered what he thought most convenient to be done. After that he let them give him *corpus Domini*, and when he had tasted thereof then he first sung this communio, *Refecti... eternam*. After that he began the psalm *Benedicam... meo*. These words run thus: 'I will praise the Lord every hour, and his praise shall ever be in my mouth' [Ps vulg xxxiii. 1]. And as he had this psalm in his mouth, and his tongue was yet moving with these holy words, his spirit departed from his body, and was borne of God's angels to that bliss that was prepared for him by Almighty God, and there he shall praise Almighty God for ever with other holy men, as he promised in the psalm which he sung last.

57

3. Now the holy bishop John departed out of this world into everlasting bliss on Saturday, ix kal. Maii [April 23]. There were then gone from the birth of Christ eleven hundred and fourteen winters [1121]. He was hallowed bishop when he was four winters of the sixth ten [52], and he sat in his bishopric fifteen winters. And when he had lived in this world threescore winters and nine altogether, he died at a good age. It was in the days of pope Calixtus the second of that name. It was also in the days of Ey-stan and Sig-urd kings of Norway, but their brother king O-laf was already dead. Bishop Thor-lac, Run-olf's son, was then bishop in Seal-holt.

58

4. The clerks that were present took good and fit care of the body of the holy bishop John [and arrayed him in a bishop's raiment], and when it was gone so far that the body was arrayed and made ready for the burial and the dirge song, and it was at the point to be carried out, then went those of the clerks that were to bear it, and took hold of the bier and tried to lift it up. Then that came about which all men thatwfer there thought a great thing — the body became so heavy that they could in no wise lift it that were appointed to bear it. This

gave them great concern, and they reasoned among themselves what might be the reason thereof. Then spake one of the clerks well and thoughtfully, and said, 'This thing must be the punishment of some fault of ours, and we must have done something unworshipfully in our service to our bishop. Now seek diligently whether he have all those things in his array that were fit and belonged to his consecration.' Then they sought and made search until they found that they had not put his finger-ring on the hand of the holy bishop John, but it was lying there on the dais. Then they took the ring and put it on his hand, and after that the same men as before went up and easily lifted the body and bore it to the burial.

59

5. The body of the holy bishop John was buried outside the church, on the south of the choir [B: outside the church eastward, near to the south wall of the choir], and a vault made over it. There his bones lay fourscore winters and somewhat less, until God made manifest his glory by fair tokens, and his halidom was taken out of the ground. Then lord Brand the bishop had him worshipfully taken up and brought into the church, and appointed worshipfully with much glory to the praise of our Lord Jesus Christ. May he glorify himself for the sake of the worthiness of this holy friend of his and his prayers, in freeing us from evil and jeopardous things, and when we depart out of this world gather our souls to his elect. Grant this, God Almighty, that liveth and reigneth one God in Trinity, per omnia secula seculorum. Amen.